

Manifold Player's Guide

This document is written to be read once before your first session, then kept nearby and used less and less over time.

How to Use This Guide

- **Before your first session:** Read this guide once, in order.
- **At the table:** Only brief clarification should be needed before play begins.
- **Afterward:** Return to specific sections only when something feels unclear or stuck.

Nothing here is meant to be memorized. Mastery shows up when you no longer need to look.

Part I — Orientation and Expectations (Read Before First Session)

1. What Kind of Game Manifold Is

Manifold is a cooperative reasoning game about how worlds change under pressure.

It is not built around winning, optimization, or tactical mastery. It is built around shared understanding, meaningful consequence, and the slow transformation of situations over time.

A Game of Shared Reasoning

Play in Manifold is driven by conversation.

Players and GM work together to:

- establish what is currently true,
- decide what they are trying to change,
- reason about constraints and uncertainty,
- and acknowledge the consequences of action.

The quality of play depends less on clever choices and more on how clearly the table can reason together.

A Game About Consequence, Not Success

Manifold does not ask whether actions succeed or fail.

Instead, it asks:

- What does this cost?
- What changes as a result?

- What pressures increase, ease, or transform?

Even effective actions can make the world less forgiving. Even setbacks can open new possibilities.

What matters is how the situation evolves.

A Game With a Living World

The world in Manifold exists independently of player action.

Pressures are already present. Conditions are already in motion. The world responds to what players do, but it is not waiting for them to act.

As play continues:

- history accumulates,
- choices leave lasting marks,
- and the situation takes on a shape that cannot simply be undone.

The game does not build toward an ending. It builds toward a changed world.

What This Means for Players

Playing Manifold means:

- engaging with uncertainty openly,
- committing to intent without guarantees,
- accepting consequence as information rather than punishment,
- and helping maintain a shared picture of the world.

If these ideas sound unfamiliar or uncomfortable, that is normal.

The rest of this guide exists to make them workable in practice.

2. What Manifold Is Not

Understanding Manifold is easier if you are clear about what it deliberately avoids.

Many familiar role-playing assumptions will *almost* fit—and then quietly fail. This section names those misfits early, so they do not distort play later.

Not a Permission-Based System

Manifold does not ask the GM to approve actions.

There is no list of allowed moves, no catalog of abilities that determine what you may attempt, and no hidden criteria for permission.

If something connects to the current state, it can be attempted.

Whether it is feasible, costly, or uncertain is determined through shared reasoning—not authorization.

Not a Success-Failure Engine

Actions in Manifold do not resolve into simple success or failure.

Dice do not answer the question “Did it work?”

They help determine:

- what the action costs,
- which pressures change,
- and how the situation is reshaped.

Looking for clean wins or clean losses will consistently misread outcomes.

Not an Adversarial Game

The GM is not an opponent.

The world is not trying to defeat the players, and consequences are not punishments for poor choices.

Pressure arises from conditions and history, not from opposition.

Treating the game as something to be beaten will usually flatten play rather than sharpen it.

Not a Tactical Optimization Puzzle

Manifold does not reward finding the best move.

Because the situation changes as consequences accumulate, optimal play in one moment may create worse conditions later.

Careful reasoning matters more than clever exploitation.

Not a Turn-Based Procedure

Play does not proceed in rounds or turns.

Multiple intents may exist at once, and the world responds to their combined effects.

Thinking in discrete action slots often obscures how pressure and consequence actually operate.

Not a Story With Planned Arcs

Manifold does not build toward predetermined climaxes or resolutions.

There is no expected narrative shape.

Stories may emerge in retrospect, but they are artifacts of change—not goals to pursue.

Why These Distinctions Matter

Each of these misunderstandings tends to produce the same problems:

- stalled play,
- unnecessary conflict,
- or outcomes that feel arbitrary.

Letting go of them allows the game to operate as intended.

The rest of this guide shows what takes their place.

3. Where Authority Lives

In Manifold, authority does not come from rules text, character sheets, or hidden GM knowledge.

Authority lives in the shared understanding of the current state of the world.

Authority Is Grounded in State

What the table agrees is *currently true* determines what can reasonably happen next.

This includes:

- established facts,
- visible pressures,
- known constraints,
- and consequences that have already occurred.

No one needs to "invoke" authority. It is present wherever the state is clear.

The Role of the GM

The GM is responsible for:

- maintaining coherence of the world,
- facilitating shared reasoning,
- and ensuring that consequences follow from state.

The GM does not grant permission for actions.

Instead, they help the table see how proposed intents interact with what is already true.

When uncertainty remains, the GM helps frame it—but does not decide outcomes in advance.

The Role of the Players

Players share responsibility for authority by:

- engaging honestly with the current state,
- pointing out relevant pressures or constraints,
- and helping maintain clarity when misalignment appears.

Challenging an interpretation of state is not challenging the GM. It is participating in the game.

Authority and Dice

Dice do not carry authority.

They do not override state, intent, or reasoning.

They only help resolve uncertainty that the table has already agreed exists.

Once a roll is interpreted, its consequences become part of the state—and authority shifts to those new facts.

When Authority Feels Unclear

If no one is sure what should happen next, this usually means:

- the current state is underspecified,
- relevant pressures have not been named,
- or consequences were not clearly recorded earlier.

The solution is not to search for a rule.

The solution is to clarify what is true.

In Manifold, authority is not held. It is shared, visible, and continuously renewed by attention to the world.

4. What Dice Do (and Do Not Do)

Dice appear in Manifold less often than in many role-playing games, but when they do, they matter.

Their purpose is narrow and precise: to resolve uncertainty that cannot be resolved by reasoning alone.

What Dice Do

Dice are used to:

- sample uncertainty that the table agrees is real and relevant,
- distinguish between multiple plausible outcomes,
- and determine which consequences occur when intent meets constraint.

A roll helps answer questions like:

- Which pressures increase, ease, or transform?
- What new facts become true as a result of this attempt?
- How costly is this outcome, even if the intent is partially achieved?

Dice provide information about the world, not judgments about player choices.

What Dice Do Not Do

Dice do **not**:

- grant permission to act,
- determine whether an action is allowed,
- decide success or failure in isolation,
- or override established state.

Rolling well does not mean the world cooperates.

Rolling poorly does not mean an intent was wrong or foolish.

The roll only clarifies how the situation changes.

Dice as a Shared Tool

Dice are introduced only after:

- intent is clearly declared,
- feasibility and constraints are discussed,
- and the table agrees that uncertainty matters.

Anyone at the table may point out when a roll seems appropriate—or when it does not.

This keeps dice from becoming a reflex or a substitute for discussion.

Why This Matters

When dice are treated as decision-makers, play becomes brittle and adversarial.

When they are treated as instruments of uncertainty, they support richer consequence and clearer state.

The rest of this guide will show exactly how and when dice enter play.

For now, remember this:

Dice do not decide what you can do. They help reveal what it costs.

5. Player Responsibilities

Manifold asks players to participate actively in maintaining a shared, intelligible world.

These responsibilities are not about performance or optimization. They are about keeping the game coherent.

Declare Intent Honestly

Players are responsible for stating what they are actually trying to make happen.

This means:

- naming goals rather than actions,
- avoiding outcomes disguised as intent,
- and accepting that intent does not guarantee success.

Clear intent gives the table something real to reason about.

Engage With the Current State

Players are expected to pay attention to what is already true.

This includes:

- existing facts,
- visible pressures,
- and constraints created by prior consequences.

Ignoring state in favor of imagined possibilities is the fastest way to stall play.

Participate in Shared Reasoning

Manifold does not outsource thinking to mechanics.

Players contribute by:

- pointing out relevant details,
- asking clarifying questions,
- and helping identify what is uncertain.

You do not need to be clever. You need to be attentive.

Accept Consequence

When outcomes reshape the situation, players are expected to take those changes seriously.

This means:

- not arguing away costs after the fact,
- not treating pressure as a mistake,
- and not searching for loopholes to erase consequences.

Consequences are information about the world, not penalties for choices.

Stay Present Through Resolution

Engagement does not end when dice are rolled.

Players remain involved by:

- listening to how outcomes are interpreted,
- helping update the shared state,
- and considering what the new situation means.

Checking out once uncertainty is resolved undermines the shared model the game depends on.

What Players Are Not Responsible For

Players are not required to:

- manage bookkeeping alone,
- adjudicate feasibility by themselves,
- or entertain the table.

Responsibility is shared, not individualized.

Manifold works when players treat the world as something they are jointly reasoning about, not something they are trying to beat.

6. Common Failure Modes (and How to Avoid Them)

Manifold tends to fail in predictable ways when familiar habits are carried in from other games.

These are not mistakes or bad behavior. They are mismatches between expectation and structure.

Recognizing them early keeps play fluid and prevents unnecessary frustration.

Waiting for Permission

This appears as:

- hesitating to declare intent,
- asking whether an action is allowed,
- or deferring to the GM for approval.

Avoid this by:

- stating what you are trying to make happen,
- grounding it in the current state,
- and letting the table reason about feasibility together.

If it connects to the world, it can be attempted.

Treating Mechanics as Menus

This appears as:

- looking for the right move,
- waiting for a trigger to roll,
- or searching the rules for optimal choices.

Avoid this by:

- focusing on intent and consequence,
- reasoning from state rather than options,
- and remembering that dice are tools, not prompts.

The game does not offer moves. It offers situations.

Expecting Dice to Decide

This appears as:

- rolling too early,
- reading results as success or failure,
- or disengaging once dice hit the table.

Avoid this by:

- clarifying uncertainty before rolling,
- interpreting results in terms of cost and change,
- and staying engaged through state updates.

Dice resolve uncertainty. They do not replace reasoning.

Optimizing Instead of Engaging Consequence

This appears as:

- minimizing pressure at all costs,
- undoing outcomes as soon as they appear,
- or avoiding commitments that might narrow options.

Avoid this by:

- accepting that pressure is information,
- allowing situations to change shape,
- and treating consequence as the engine of play.

Stability is not the goal.

Disengaging After Resolution

This appears as:

- checking out once a roll is complete,
- ignoring updated state,
- or treating outcomes as someone else's problem.

Avoid this by:

- helping articulate consequences,
- confirming what is now true,
- and considering what the new situation demands.

Resolution is not the end of play. It is the hinge.

When Failure Modes Appear

If any of these patterns show up:

- pause briefly,
- restate the current state,
- and identify which assumption is being imported.

No correction or enforcement is required.

Clarity resolves most failure modes on its own.

Manifold does not break when these habits appear. It only slows until they are released.

Part II — A World That Already Exists (The Example Situation)

7. The Situation

This guide uses a single, deliberately mundane situation that will remain with us throughout the document.

Nothing about this situation is urgent, dramatic, or exceptional. It is chosen precisely because it does **not** look like the beginning of an adventure.

At the start of play, the world is already in motion—but no one is acting yet.

The Setting (Initial Snapshot)

- A small river town sits at the junction of an old trade road and a newer rail spur.
- Most people know one another by sight, if not by name.
- The town functions adequately. It is not thriving, and it is not collapsing.

There is no crisis. No attack. No ticking clock.

Why This Situation Was Chosen

This situation exists to demonstrate that Manifold does not require:

- obvious danger,
- heroic stakes,
- or immediate conflict

to produce engaging play.

If something becomes interesting here, it will be because of **how people act, what pressures accumulate, and how consequences reshape possibility**—not because the situation was designed to be exciting.

What Is (and Is Not) Happening Yet

At this point:

- No player has declared intent.
- No dice have been rolled.
- No pressure has advanced.
- No outcomes have been decided.

This is not a pause before the game starts.

This **is** the starting state of the game.

Everything that follows will emerge from changes to this situation.

For now, hold this image loosely. We will return to it repeatedly, but nothing here will move until play actually begins.

8. The Entities

The situation includes a small number of entities. These are not characters in a story and they are not pieces on a board.

They are simply things in the world that already exist, already have relationships, and already exert influence.

Nothing about these entities is hidden. Nothing about them is secret.

The Town Council

- A small group of locally respected figures.
- They oversee maintenance, permits, and local ordinances.
- Decisions are slow, procedural, and shaped by reputation rather than law.

At present, the council is divided, but functional.

The Mill

- The largest employer in the area.
- Privately owned, but tightly coupled to the town's wellbeing.
- Its operation affects trade, river traffic, and seasonal labor.

The mill is operating normally.

The River

- Used for transport, waste runoff, and local fishing.
- Changes slowly, but influences many aspects of daily life.
- No one controls it, but many depend on it.

The river is within expected seasonal bounds.

The Rail Spur

- A newer addition to the town's infrastructure.
- Improves access to distant markets.
- Brings outside attention, schedules, and expectations.

The spur is active, but underutilized.

The People

- Workers, merchants, families, and travelers.
- No unified agenda.

- Individual concerns exist, but are not yet aligned.

No group is mobilized.

What These Entities Mean

These entities are not opponents, allies, or quest-givers.

They are sources of pressure, constraint, and possibility.

As play progresses:

- Their relationships may shift.
- Their influence may grow or weaken.
- New facts may become true about them.

For now, they simply exist.

Nothing here demands action. But everything here will matter once action is taken.

9. Existing Pressures

Even though nothing is happening yet, the situation is not neutral.

Pressure already exists in the world. It does not announce itself as danger, urgency, or conflict. It simply accumulates when conditions persist without resolution.

In this example, we will track three ongoing pressures. These are not meters of success or failure. They describe how the situation becomes more constrained over time.

Economic Strain

- The town's economy is stable, but thin.
- The mill provides most employment, and alternatives are limited.
- Small disruptions have outsized effects.

This pressure increases when: - work slows or stops, - trade is interrupted, - or uncertainty discourages investment.

Institutional Friction

- Decision-making relies on informal consensus.
- Authority is distributed, not centralized.
- Process is slow, even when agreement exists.

This pressure increases when: - decisions are delayed, - responsibilities are unclear, - or trust in institutions erodes.

Environmental Stress

- The river is predictable, but not controllable.
- Infrastructure assumes normal conditions.
- Maintenance is adequate, not robust.

This pressure increases when: - small problems are ignored, - maintenance is deferred, - or external conditions shift.

What These Pressures Do

Pressure tracks do not represent threats waiting to attack.

They represent **how forgiving the situation is**.

As pressure rises: - some approaches become harder, - some outcomes become less likely, - and some options disappear entirely.

No one needs to act for pressure to exist.

Pressure is already present.

Later, we will see how pressure changes are recorded, when they matter, and how they reshape what is possible.

10. The Current State

The current state is a summary of what is true *right now*.

It is not a prediction, a plan, or a list of options. It is a snapshot of reality as everyone at the table understands it before any action is taken.

At the start of play, the current state includes the following facts:

What Is Stable

- The town is functioning.
- The mill is operating.
- Trade and transport continue without interruption.
- The river remains within expected seasonal bounds.

These facts are not guarantees. They are simply true at this moment.

What Is Under Strain

- Economic margins are thin and sensitive to disruption.
- Institutional decisions take time and depend on trust.

- Infrastructure assumes normal conditions and regular upkeep.

None of these have failed. They are merely *less forgiving* than they appear.

What Is Uncertain

- How long current stability can be maintained without adjustment.
- Which pressures will become relevant first.
- How people will respond if conditions begin to shift.

Uncertainty does not demand immediate resolution.

What Has Not Yet Happened

- No commitments have been made.
- No conflicts have surfaced.
- No consequences have been triggered.

Nothing is waiting to be revealed.

Why This Matters

The current state is the foundation for everything that follows.

When players declare intent, they do so *against this state*. When dice are rolled, they sample uncertainty *within this state*. When consequences occur, they *change this state*.

If play ever feels confusing or stalled, returning to the current state is often enough to restore alignment.

This is the last moment where the world is fully intact. From here on, change only happens because of what people do.

Part III — Tools Before Motion

11. Shared Narration

In Manifold, narration is shared. This does not mean everyone is telling a story together, and it does not mean anyone can declare outcomes.

Shared narration means that players actively contribute to **what is true**, **what is visible**, and **what is relevant**, while remaining grounded in the current state.

What Shared Narration Is

Shared narration is the act of adding, clarifying, or refining details about the situation so that everyone at the table understands the same world.

This includes:

- Describing how your character approaches something.
- Naming environmental details that are consistent with what is already true.
- Clarifying relationships, positions, timing, or visibility.
- Asking questions that tighten shared understanding.

These contributions help the table reason together about what can happen next.

What Shared Narration Is Not

Shared narration is **not**:

- Declaring success or failure.
- Introducing consequences by fiat.
- Overriding established state.
- Adding details that resolve uncertainty on their own.

If a narrated detail would change what is possible or remove uncertainty, it does not happen automatically. It becomes something the table must reason about together.

Grounding Narration in State

All narration must remain consistent with the current state.

Before adding a detail, ask yourself:

- Does this follow from what is already true?
- Does this respect existing pressures and constraints?
- Does this add clarity rather than resolution?

If the answer is unclear, that uncertainty belongs in conversation, not narration.

Shared Narration and Authority

Narration does not grant authority. Authority comes from shared understanding.

When narration creates disagreement or confusion, play pauses briefly to realign. This is not an interruption—it *is* the game doing its job.

Clarifying narration early prevents disputes later, especially once dice and consequences enter play.

Using the Example Situation

At this point in the guide, our example situation remains unchanged.

We can describe:

- what the town looks like on an ordinary day,
- how people move through shared spaces,
- what signs of strain might be quietly visible,

without advancing time, pressure, or outcomes.

Nothing has happened yet—but we now have a richer, more precise shared picture.

Shared narration builds the surface on which intent, uncertainty, and consequence can later operate.

12. Declaring Intent

Declaring intent is how play begins to move.

An intent declaration answers a single question:

What are you trying to make happen, given the world as it currently exists?

It does not describe how success is achieved, and it does not assume that success is guaranteed.

What an Intent Is

An intent is a statement of purpose directed at the situation, not a script of actions.

Good intent declarations:

- name a goal or change you are aiming for,
- stay grounded in the current state,
- leave room for uncertainty and consequence.

Examples of intent phrasing include:

- "I want to secure continued work at the mill through the next season."
- "I'm trying to get the council aligned enough to approve maintenance."
- "I want to prevent the river situation from becoming a larger problem."

Each of these names a direction, not an outcome.

What an Intent Is Not

An intent is **not**:

- a list of actions,
- a declaration of success,

- a demand for permission,
- or a plan that bypasses uncertainty.

Statements like “I convince them,” “I fix the problem,” or “I make it work” skip the part of play where reasoning, risk, and consequence matter.

Why Intent Comes Before Resolution

Manifold resolves situations by reasoning about consequences, not by checking whether an action is allowed.

Declaring intent first allows the table to:

- confirm shared understanding of the situation,
- identify what is actually at stake,
- notice constraints or pressures that matter,
- and decide whether uncertainty needs to be sampled.

Only after intent is clear does the table move toward resolution.

Multiple Intents and Simultaneity

More than one player may declare intent at the same time.

When this happens:

- intents are placed side by side,
- interactions between them are discussed,
- and potential conflicts or alignments are surfaced.

No intent resolves in isolation.

Simultaneity is not a special rule—it is a reminder that the world responds to *everything that is happening*, not one action at a time.

Using the Example Situation

At this point in the guide, we still do not resolve anything.

We can imagine possible intents directed at the town, the council, the mill, or the river, but we do not yet act on them.

Declaring intent prepares the ground. Resolution comes later.

Intent gives play its direction. Everything else determines what that direction costs.

13. Feasibility and Constraints

Once intent is declared, the table reasons about feasibility.

This is not a check for permission. It is a shared examination of whether the stated intent can meaningfully interact with the current state of the world.

What Feasibility Means

Feasibility asks:

- Does the intent connect to things that actually exist?
- Are there paths from the current state to the desired change?
- What pressures or conditions bear directly on this attempt?

An intent can be *meaningful* even if it is risky, costly, or likely to fail. Feasibility is about **contact with reality**, not likelihood of success.

Constraints Are Already Present

Constraints do not appear because someone declares an intent.

They are already embedded in:

- the current state,
- existing pressures,
- the relationships between entities,
- and the limits of time, trust, resources, and attention.

Discussing constraints is the act of making those limits explicit.

How the Table Reasons Together

When considering feasibility, players and GM collaboratively:

- point to relevant facts in the current state,
- reference pressures that might matter,
- identify uncertainties that cannot be resolved by reasoning alone,
- and agree on what is actually at stake.

This conversation is not negotiation. It is alignment.

If disagreement arises, it usually signals that the current state is being imagined differently by different people.

Feasible, Infeasible, and Unclear Intents

After discussion, an intent will usually fall into one of three categories:

- **Clearly feasible:** The intent can proceed without sampling uncertainty.
- **Clearly infeasible:** The intent cannot meaningfully act on the current state as described.
- **Unclear:** The intent depends on factors that are uncertain or contested.

Only the third case creates a reason to involve dice.

Using the Example Situation

In our example, many intents are feasible without immediate resolution.

Others would clearly fail to connect to the current state.

Most interesting intents, however, will sit in the unclear space—where pressures, trust, timing, or incomplete information matter.

We still do not roll dice here.

We are identifying *why* a roll might be needed later.

Feasibility is about respecting the world as it is, before asking it to change.

14. Visibility and Bookkeeping

Manifold keeps state visible.

This is not for enforcement, tracking turns, or limiting actions. It is to support shared understanding so that reasoning can happen in the open.

Bookkeeping externalizes memory.

Why State Is Visible

When state is hidden, players are forced to guess what matters. When state is visible, players can reason together about what is true and what has changed.

Visibility allows the table to:

- notice pressure before it becomes crisis,
- see how consequences accumulate,
- and understand why certain approaches become harder or impossible.

Nothing about visibility grants permission or authority. It only reduces ambiguity.

What Is Bookkept

Bookkeeping records *conditions*, not actions.

Typical elements include:

- pressure tracks,
- notable facts that have become true,
- constraints that now exist,
- and changes to relationships or capabilities.

These records describe the world, not what players are allowed to do.

What Bookkeeping Is Not

Bookkeeping is **not**:

- a checklist of required actions,
- a scorecard of success or failure,
- a turn order or timing system,
- or a list of options.

If bookkeeping ever feels like it is telling you what to do next, something has gone wrong.

Shared Responsibility

Anyone at the table may:

- point out a change that should be recorded,
- ask whether a pressure should increase,
- or request clarification of what is currently true.

This is not challenging the GM. It is maintaining alignment.

Preparing for Motion

At this point in the guide, we still have not changed the example situation.

What we have done is prepare a surface where change can be seen when it occurs.

In the next section, we will use the example to show how this surface remains static even as hypothetical actions are discussed—and why no bookkeeping changes yet.

Bookkeeping does not drive play. It makes play legible.

15. Using the Example (Without Advancing It)

Up to this point, we have introduced a situation, named entities, identified pressures, and clarified the current state.

We have also explained how narration, intent, feasibility, and bookkeeping work.

What we have **not** done is change anything.

This is intentional.

Talking About Action Is Not Taking Action

It is possible—and often necessary—to talk through potential actions without committing to them.

In Manifold, discussion serves to:

- clarify what an intent would actually touch,
- surface constraints and pressures that matter,
- determine whether uncertainty exists,
- and align the table on what is at stake.

None of these steps, by themselves, advance time or alter state.

Hypothetical Intents

Using the example situation, players might say things like:

- “If someone tried to push the council to act quickly, that would run into institutional friction.”
- “Trying to stabilize the mill without addressing the river would leave environmental stress unchanged.”
- “Delaying action here would probably increase economic strain.”

These statements are observations, not commitments.

They help everyone understand the shape of the situation before anything happens.

Why Nothing Changes Yet

State only changes when:

- an intent is actually pursued,
- uncertainty is resolved,
- and consequences are established.

Until then:

- no pressure increases,

- no facts are updated,
- and no bookkeeping is performed.

This prevents accidental progress and keeps the focus on understanding rather than momentum.

Recognizing the Transition Point

Play begins to move when the table collectively agrees that:

- an intent is being acted on,
- feasibility has been examined,
- and remaining uncertainty matters enough to resolve.

That moment—not narration, not discussion, not speculation—is when the game shifts from preparation to action.

In the next part of this guide, we will cross that line.

Knowing when nothing has happened yet is just as important as knowing when something finally does.

Part IV — When Play Begins

16. The First Declarations

This is the point where play begins to move.

Until now, everything has been preparation: shared understanding, clarified state, and alignment around how reasoning works. Here, players begin to act on the situation.

Declaring Real Intents

Players now state intents that they actually intend to pursue.

These declarations are no longer hypothetical. Each intent represents a commitment to engage the world and accept whatever consequences follow.

Using the example situation, the table might hear intents such as:

- “I’m going to try to get the council to prioritize river maintenance before the next council meeting.”
- “I want to secure assurances from the mill owner that layoffs won’t happen this season.”
- “I’m trying to understand how close the rail authority is to changing its shipping schedule.”

Each intent is grounded in the current state and directed at a real source of pressure.

Multiple Intents at Once

More than one intent can be declared before anything is resolved.

In fact, this is the normal case.

When multiple intents are on the table:

- they are considered together,
- their interactions are discussed,
- and their combined effects on the situation are examined.

The world does not pause to resolve one thing at a time. Consequences accumulate from everything that is happening.

Clarifying Before Acting

Before moving toward resolution, the table briefly confirms:

- that everyone understands each intent,
- what each intent is trying to change,
- and which pressures or constraints are likely to be involved.

This clarification is not delay. It prevents misaligned resolution and unintended consequences.

The State Is Still Stable

At the end of this step:

- no dice have been rolled,
- no pressure has advanced,
- and no bookkeeping has changed.

Intent alone does not alter the world.

What it does is **commit the table to finding out what it will cost.**

Once intent is declared, the situation is no longer hypothetical. The next question is how uncertainty is resolved.

17. Deciding Whether a Roll Is Needed

After intent is declared and feasibility is discussed, the table decides whether uncertainty needs to be resolved.

Rolling dice is not automatic. It is a deliberate choice made only when reasoning alone cannot determine what happens next.

When No Roll Is Needed

No roll is required when:

- the intent is clearly feasible and uncontested,
- the outcome follows directly from the current state,
- or the consequences are already obvious.

In these cases, the world simply changes.

State is updated, pressure may increase or decrease, and play moves on without interruption.

This is not “skipping mechanics.” This *is* the mechanic doing its job.

When a Roll Is Needed

A roll is introduced only when:

- relevant uncertainty remains after discussion,
- multiple plausible outcomes exist,
- and the difference between those outcomes matters.

Uncertainty can come from:

- incomplete information,
- competing pressures,
- limited time or attention,
- or conflicting efforts happening at once.

If uncertainty does not matter, it is not rolled.

What the Roll Is For

A roll does **not** answer the question “Do you succeed?”

Instead, it samples uncertainty to help determine:

- which consequences occur,
- how costly the outcome is,
- or which pressures advance.

The intent still matters. The roll only helps decide what it costs to pursue it.

Using the Example Situation

In our example, some declared intents would clearly proceed without a roll.

Others would clearly fail to connect to the current state.

The most interesting cases are those where:

- success is possible,
- failure is possible,
- and the difference meaningfully reshapes the situation.

Those are the moments when dice enter play.

Dice are used to resolve uncertainty, not to grant permission.

18. Rolling Dice

When a roll is called for, it represents a moment where reasoning alone is no longer sufficient.

The table understands what is being attempted, what pressures are involved, and what could plausibly happen—but not which of those outcomes will occur.

Rolling dice samples that uncertainty.

What a Roll Represents

A roll does **not** represent effort, skill, or chance in the abstract.

It represents the interaction between:

- the current state,
- the declared intent,
- the relevant pressures and constraints,
- and factors that cannot be resolved by discussion alone.

The dice stand in for everything the table agrees is uncertain *right now*.

Framing the Roll

Before dice are rolled, the table briefly agrees on:

- what the roll is meant to clarify,
- which pressures or conditions are likely to be affected,
- and what kinds of consequences are on the table.

This framing is not about predicting outcomes. It ensures that everyone understands what the roll can and cannot decide.

If the table cannot agree on this framing, the roll should not happen yet.

Reading the Result

A roll result is interpreted in context.

Rather than asking “Did this work?”, the table asks:

- What does this result say about cost?
- Which pressures advance or recede?
- What new facts become true?

Low results do not necessarily mean failure. High results do not guarantee clean success.

The meaning of the roll emerges from how it reshapes the situation.

Using the Example Situation

In our example, a roll might determine:

- whether institutional friction increases as a decision is rushed,
- whether economic strain is eased or merely delayed,
- or whether environmental stress is contained or displaced.

Regardless of the outcome, something *changes*.

That change is what matters.

After the Roll

Once the roll is interpreted:

- consequences are stated clearly,
- state is updated visibly,
- and play continues from the new situation.

The roll is complete.

Dice do not end scenes. They transform situations.

19. Updating State

After a roll is interpreted, the situation changes.

Updating state is the act of making those changes explicit, visible, and shared.

This is not bookkeeping for its own sake. It is how the table acknowledges that the world is now different than it was before.

What It Means to Update State

Updating state involves clearly stating:

- what new facts are now true,
- which pressures have changed,
- and what constraints now exist that did not before.

These updates describe the *world*, not the actions that led to them.

Once stated and recorded, they become part of the shared reality going forward.

How Pressure Changes

Pressure tracks may:

- increase,
- decrease,
- split into new forms,
- or transform into different kinds of constraint.

An increase does not mean failure. It means the situation has become less forgiving in a particular way.

A decrease does not mean success. It may represent relief, delay, or displacement of cost.

Recording the Change

Changes are recorded where everyone can see them.

This might include:

- adjusting pressure tracks,
- adding short notes about newly true conditions,
- or marking shifts in relationships or capabilities.

The record should be concise and factual.

If something feels difficult to write down, that often means it has not been clearly understood yet.

The First State Snapshot

At this point, the example situation has changed for the first time.

A simple state snapshot might now show:

- one pressure increased,
- another remaining stable,
- and a new constraint noted alongside the relevant entity.

This snapshot does not explain *why* the change happened.

It shows *that* it has happened.

(Insert first state diagram here.)

Continuing From the New State

Once state is updated:

- new intents may be declared,
- feasibility is reconsidered in light of the change,
- and play continues from the altered situation.

Nothing resets.

Every update carries forward.

Play does not move from scene to scene. It moves from state to state.

Part V — Consequence in Motion

20. Pressure Accumulation

Once the state has changed, pressure begins to accumulate over time.

Pressure accumulation is not a countdown to failure. It is a record of how the situation becomes less forgiving as unresolved conditions persist or compound.

Pressure Accumulates Through Consequence

Pressure increases when:

- actions produce side effects that are not fully addressed,
- problems are deferred rather than resolved,
- resources are strained by repeated use,
- or trust erodes through partial or costly outcomes.

Pressure does **not** increase simply because time passes.

It increases because consequences stack.

Multiple Pressures at Once

More than one pressure may advance from a single sequence of events.

For example:

- easing economic strain might increase institutional friction,
- addressing environmental stress might divert resources elsewhere,
- stabilizing one area might expose fragility in another.

Pressure tracks are independent, but they interact through the shared state.

What Rising Pressure Changes

As pressure accumulates:

- some intents become harder to pursue,
- some approaches carry greater cost,
- and some previously reasonable options disappear.

This does not mean the situation is getting worse in a simple sense.

It means the shape of the situation is changing.

Pressure Without Crisis

Pressure can accumulate without triggering immediate disaster.

A situation under high pressure may:

- continue functioning,
- appear stable on the surface,
- and even improve in some respects.

The difference is that fewer mistakes are tolerated, and fewer easy paths remain.

Using the Example Situation

As play continues in the example:

- repeated partial successes may ease one pressure while intensifying another,
- delays may quietly increase strain without visible conflict,
- and well-intentioned actions may narrow future options.

Nothing here ends the game.

It simply reshapes what the next intent will cost.

Pressure does not punish action. It records its weight.

21. Thresholds and Transformation

As pressure accumulates, the situation may cross thresholds.

A threshold is not a failure state or an endpoint. It is a qualitative change in how the world behaves.

Crossing a threshold means that something which was previously possible is no longer possible—or that something previously difficult becomes unavoidable.

What Thresholds Are

Thresholds represent structural shifts in the situation.

They may:

- introduce new constraints,
- remove previously available approaches,
- change who or what can meaningfully act,
- or alter which pressures matter most.

A threshold does not end play. It changes the terrain on which play continues.

What Thresholds Are Not

Thresholds are **not**:

- win or loss conditions,
- narrative climaxes,
- automatic disasters,
- or punishments for poor choices.

They are the result of accumulated consequence, not a judgment on player decisions.

Living With a Transformed Situation

After a threshold is crossed:

- the current state is updated to reflect the new reality,
- future intents must respect the transformed conditions,
- and new forms of pressure may emerge.

Importantly, transformation often clarifies the situation.

Some uncertainties disappear. Others become sharper.

Using the Example Situation

In the example, a threshold might:

- shift institutional friction into open opposition,
- turn environmental stress into a standing limitation,
- or convert economic strain into permanent scarcity.

None of these end the situation.

They simply redefine what "normal" now looks like.

Why This Matters

Thresholds ensure that play evolves.

They prevent indefinite stalling, erase the illusion of reversibility, and make earlier choices matter without declaring anyone victorious or defeated.

Crossing a threshold does not conclude a story. It commits the world to a new shape.

22. Continued Play Flow

Once pressure has accumulated and thresholds have reshaped the situation, play continues.

There is no new phase, no escalation mode, and no reset.

The same loop repeats—now operating on a transformed state.

The Loop Revisited

Play continues through the same sequence:

- the current state is acknowledged,
- players declare new intents,
- feasibility and constraints are examined,
- uncertainty is resolved when needed,
- consequences are established,
- and state is updated again.

Nothing about this loop changes after thresholds are crossed.

What changes is *what the world will tolerate*.

Increasing Specificity

As play proceeds:

- intents tend to become narrower and more specific,
- constraints become clearer and harder to bypass,
- and consequences become more sharply defined.

This is not because the game is closing in on an ending.

It is because the situation has accumulated history.

No Return to Neutral

The game does not return to a baseline.

Earlier choices continue to matter, even when the immediate context shifts.

Relief, recovery, and adaptation are possible—but they occur within the new shape of the world, not by erasing it.

When Play Slows or Stalls

If play begins to feel repetitive or stuck, the solution is rarely to add new mechanics.

Instead, the table can:

- revisit the current state together,
- look for pressures that have quietly grown significant,
- or acknowledge that a threshold has already been crossed.

Clarity restores motion.

Using the Example Situation

By this point in the example, the original town no longer exists in its initial form.

It is recognizably the same place, but shaped by accumulated consequence.

Play could continue here indefinitely, or attention could shift elsewhere.

Nothing needs to conclude.

Manifold does not build toward endings. It builds toward changed worlds.

Part VI — Table Etiquette and Shared Culture

23. Productive Table Language

Manifold relies on conversation as its primary engine.

The way players speak at the table has a direct impact on clarity, momentum, and trust. Productive language supports shared reasoning without assigning blame or asserting authority.

This section is not about politeness. It is about keeping the game legible.

Language That Helps Play Move

Certain kinds of phrasing consistently improve alignment and flow. Examples include:

- “Here’s what I think is true right now...”
- “If that’s the case, then this pressure probably matters.”
- “I’m not sure whether this is feasible given the current state.”
- “What would this change if it worked?”
- “Do we agree on what’s uncertain here?”

These statements:

- invite clarification rather than demand agreement,
- reference shared state rather than personal authority,
- and keep attention on consequences instead of correctness.

Language That Tends to Stall Play

Other kinds of phrasing often introduce friction or confusion, even when well intentioned:

- “Can I do this?”
- “The rules say...”
- “That shouldn’t be allowed.”
- “I already rolled well, so...”
- “That’s not realistic.”

These phrases usually signal misalignment about state, authority, or uncertainty.

When they appear, it is often useful to pause and restate what is currently true rather than argue about outcomes.

Reframing Instead of Correcting

When someone uses unproductive language, the goal is not to correct them.

Instead, try reframing:

- Replace “You can’t do that” with “I don’t see how that connects to the current state.”
- Replace “That fails” with “Here’s what that costs or changes.”
- Replace “The roll means I win” with “Let’s look at what the result actually affects.”

Reframing keeps conversation collaborative and forward-looking.

Shared Responsibility for Tone

Any player may model productive language.

This is not the GM’s job alone.

When the table consistently speaks in terms of state, pressure, and consequence, misunderstandings resolve themselves quickly.

Good table language does not tell anyone what to do. It helps everyone see the same world.

24. Disagreement and Misalignment

Disagreement is not a failure state in Manifold.

It is a signal that different players are holding different models of the current situation.

Because the game relies on shared reasoning, noticing misalignment early is a strength, not a disruption.

What Misalignment Looks Like

Misalignment often appears as:

- surprise at an outcome,
- disagreement about whether something is feasible,
- confusion over what a roll actually affected,
- or repeated attempts to resolve the same issue in different ways.

These moments are not problems to push through. They are indicators that the shared state needs clarification.

Pausing to Realign

When misalignment appears, play briefly slows.

This pause is used to:

- restate what each person believes is currently true,
- identify where those understandings differ,

- and reconcile them into a single shared picture.

No one is assigning blame or defending a position. The goal is alignment, not agreement about intent or preference.

Authority During Disagreement

During realignment, authority comes from:

- what has already been established in state,
- what consequences have already occurred,
- and what the table can jointly support as reasonable.

The GM facilitates this process, but does not "win" disagreements by fiat.

If something was unclear earlier, it is clarified now and carried forward consistently.

Preventing Escalation

Most table conflict escalates when disagreement is mistaken for opposition.

Treating misalignment as a shared maintenance task prevents:

- rule debates,
- adversarial positioning,
- and personal frustration.

Clarity dissolves tension more reliably than compromise.

Returning to Play

Once the shared picture is restored:

- the current state is confirmed or adjusted,
- any necessary bookkeeping is updated,
- and play resumes from the clarified situation.

Nothing else needs to be resolved.

When everyone sees the same world again, the game moves on by itself.

25. Trust, Comfort, and Engagement

Manifold works best when players remain present, curious, and comfortable engaging with uncertainty.

This is not a matter of tone policing or emotional performance. It is a structural requirement of a game that relies on shared reasoning.

Trust as a Structural Condition

Trust in Manifold does not mean assuming good outcomes.

It means trusting that:

- consequences will follow from the state, not from hidden agendas,
- uncertainty will be handled openly,
- and clarification is always preferable to pushing forward in confusion.

When trust is present, players are willing to declare intent honestly and accept costly or unexpected outcomes.

Comfort Without Control

Players should feel comfortable expressing uncertainty, confusion, or hesitation.

This does not require consensus, agreement, or emotional alignment.

It requires only that:

- questions are welcomed,
- pauses for clarification are respected,
- and no one is pressured to act before they understand the situation.

Comfort supports engagement by reducing the impulse to disengage or defer responsibility.

Engagement as Participation

Engagement in Manifold is not measured by spotlight time or dramatic contribution.

It is measured by:

- attention to the current state,
- willingness to reason about consequence,
- and participation during moments of uncertainty.

A quiet player who helps clarify state is engaged.

A vocal player who disengages after rolling is not.

Recognizing Disengagement

Disengagement often appears as:

- defaulting to dice instead of discussion,
- checking out once consequences are established,
- or avoiding intent declaration when stakes rise.

These are not failures. They are signals that alignment or comfort may need attention.

Supporting One Another

Any player may:

- ask for a pause,
- request clarification,
- or suggest revisiting the current state.

This is not interrupting play.

It is maintaining the conditions that allow play to continue meaningfully.

A Manifold table is not held together by agreement or enthusiasm, but by sustained attention to a shared world.

Part VII — Using This Guide as Reference

26. When to Look Things Up

The Player's Guide is not meant to be consulted constantly during play.

If it is open all the time, something upstream is unclear.

This section describes the moments when returning to the guide is useful—and when it is not.

Look Things Up When Alignment Is Lost

The most common reason to consult the guide is misalignment.

Signs include:

- disagreement about what is currently true,
- uncertainty about whether a roll is appropriate,
- confusion about what a result actually changed,
- or repeated discussion that does not resolve.

In these cases, the guide can help re-anchor the table in shared concepts: state, intent, feasibility, and consequence.

Look Things Up When Play Stalls

If play begins to feel static, circular, or hesitant, the issue is often not a lack of options, but a lack of clarity.

The guide can be useful to:

- revisit how intent is framed,
- confirm how pressure accumulates,
- or remember what thresholds represent.

Often, a brief reminder is enough to restore momentum.

Do Not Look Things Up to Seek Permission

The guide is not a list of allowed actions.

Looking things up to answer questions like:

- “Can I do this?”
- “Is this permitted?”
- “What is the correct move?”

will usually slow play rather than help it.

Those questions are resolved by reasoning from the current state, not by consulting text.

Do Not Look Things Up to Resolve Disagreement

Disagreements are resolved by clarifying shared understanding, not by citing passages.

The guide can support that clarification, but it should not be used as an authority to override conversation.

If a rule seems to contradict what the table understands, align first. Interpret second.

Using the Guide Lightly

As familiarity grows, the need to consult the guide should decrease.

This is a sign of successful play, not forgotten rules.

When in doubt, return to the state. Most questions answer themselves there.

The guide exists to restore clarity, not to direct action.

27. What to Revisit

Different kinds of friction call for revisiting different ideas.

This section helps you quickly identify *where* to look when something feels off, without rereading the entire guide.

If Actions Feel Blocked or Arbitrary

Revisit:

- **The Current State** — What is actually true right now?
- **Feasibility and Constraints** — Are limits being assumed instead of identified?

Often, what feels like a blocked action is a mismatch between intent and state.

If Dice Are Being Overused or Underused

Revisit:

- **Deciding Whether a Roll Is Needed** — Does uncertainty truly matter here?
- **Rolling Dice** — What is the roll meant to clarify?

If rolls are frequent, uncertainty may not be well-framed. If rolls never occur, uncertainty may be ignored.

If Outcomes Feel Unsatisfying

Revisit:

- **Updating State** — Were consequences made explicit and visible?
- **Pressure Accumulation** — Did costs actually register in the situation?

Unsatisfying outcomes often come from consequences that were implied but not recorded.

If Play Feels Repetitive or Stalled

Revisit:

- **Pressure Accumulation** — What has been quietly increasing?
- **Thresholds and Transformation** — Has the situation already changed shape?

Stalling usually means the world has changed more than the table has acknowledged.

If Disagreements Keep Returning

Revisit:

- **Shared Narration** — Are details being added consistently?
- **Disagreement and Misalignment** — Has alignment actually been restored?

Recurring disagreement often signals unresolved differences in imagined state.

If Engagement Drops

Revisit:

- **Declaring Intent** — Are players committing to meaningful change?
- **Trust, Comfort, and Engagement** — Are pauses and questions being respected?

Low engagement is usually a signal, not a failure.

Using This Section

This is not a checklist to run every session.

It is a map back to clarity when play loses its footing.

Most problems resolve themselves once the right part of the game is brought back into focus.

28. Letting the Guide Fade

This guide is not meant to stay at the center of play.

If sessions feel fluent—if intent, consequence, and state changes are handled naturally—then the guide has already done its job.

From Reference to Background

Over time:

- concepts introduced here should become habits,
- terminology should become shorthand,
- and clarification should happen through conversation rather than citation.

This is expected.

Returning to the guide less often is a sign that shared understanding is strong.

When the Guide Reappears

Even experienced tables may occasionally return to the guide.

This usually happens when:

- the situation becomes unusually complex,
- new players join the table,
- or long-running pressures reshape the world in unfamiliar ways.

Using the guide in these moments is not regression. It is maintenance.

No Mastery Threshold

There is no point at which you "graduate" from Manifold.

Understanding deepens as situations grow more intricate, not because rules change, but because consequences compound.

The guide does not contain advanced techniques hidden behind experience. Everything you need has already been introduced.

Closing

If you find yourself rarely opening this guide, that is success.

The game now lives in the shared attention of the table, not on the page.

When the guide fades, the world remains.